



Dressed as Data

A Matched-Dossier Test of What Moves an Evaluation-of-Evaluation Panel Score

Osei Vandermeer · Casimir Beng — School of Continuous Improvement

The problem

Evaluation of Evaluation panels certify that a review considered the case, not its presentation. Little is known about whether an identical dossier still earns a different score once one copy carries a one-page summary chart and its twin does not.

Research questions

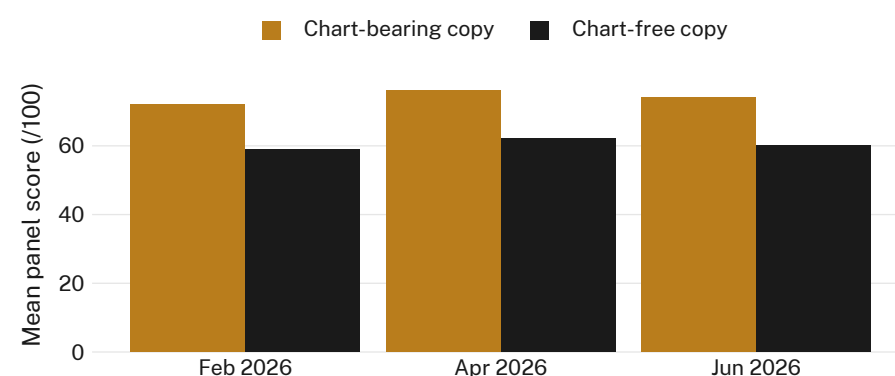
- Does an added summary chart shift panel scores when dossier text is held fixed?
- How does any shift compare to the review's own certified score-tolerance band?
- Do written justifications lean on figures absent from the shared text?

Study design

- 58 EoE panellists · 3 review cycles · matched-pair dossier design
- One arm received the identical dossier plus a Living-Dashboard-style summary chart
- Chart-arm assignment and score tolerance pre-registered; panel blind to the manipulation

Findings

Panel score for the chart-bearing dossier ran 13–15 points ahead of its chart-free twin in every cycle, a gap the certified tolerance band treats as a genuine difference in case quality. Written justifications in the chart arm cited a chart-only figure in 41% of cases.



Mean panel score for the chart-bearing copy exceeded its chart-free twin by 13–15 points in all three review cycles between February and June 2026 (n = 58 panellists), despite the two dossiers differing only in the added chart.

What it means

A score-tolerance band built to certify substance treated roughly a fifth of a typical pass margin as chart, not case. The gap held across all three cycles and did not narrow after panellists were reminded, at the second cycle, that dossier content was fixed — consistent with a presentation effect the review's current safeguards do not reach. The Evaluation-of-Evaluation program's own meta-review remit audits scoring consistency but not the artefacts a score responds to, so a figure that changes the outcome passes through uncensored. Next: extend the matched-pair design to grant and promotion dossiers, and pre-register a chart-blind reading as standard EoE practice.

Selected references

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4. Marsh, H. W., Jayasinghe, U. W., & Bond, N. W. (2008). Improving the peer-review process for grant applications: Reliability, validity, bias, and generalizability. *American Psychologist*, 63(3), 160–168. doi:10.1037/0003-066X.63.3.160

Panel assignment randomised and pre-registered; written justifications de-identified before coding. No panellist identity retained beyond cycle metadata.

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